

1500–1560

FROM DRAPE TO SHAPE

Soft, draped lines began to disappear as the century went on. Women's dress had two main parts: bodice and skirt, and sleeves were often separate too. The gradual move from clothing that draped over the body to clothing that shaped it was complete. Only outer robes and coats were now waistless. Full skirts widened with gathered and pleated waistlines. Outer skirts were opened up in front to reveal a petticoat or forepart underneath. The Spanish farthingale (a hooped petticoat) created a bell shape and defined the century's silhouette. Bodices became smooth and fitted by adding stiff materials inside. While the torso straightened, sleeves grew larger and more elaborate.



Triangular shapes Catherine Parr, last wife of Henry VIII, shows off the smooth, triangular shapes achieved by reinforced support beneath outer clothing. The silver-gilt fabric of this gown from 1545 is woven with a large pomegranate pattern.

Heavily pleated skirt The 15th-century obsession with pleating continued in Germanic fashions. This woman's dress is laced open in the front and has an embroidered breast-band under her gollar (shoulder cape).

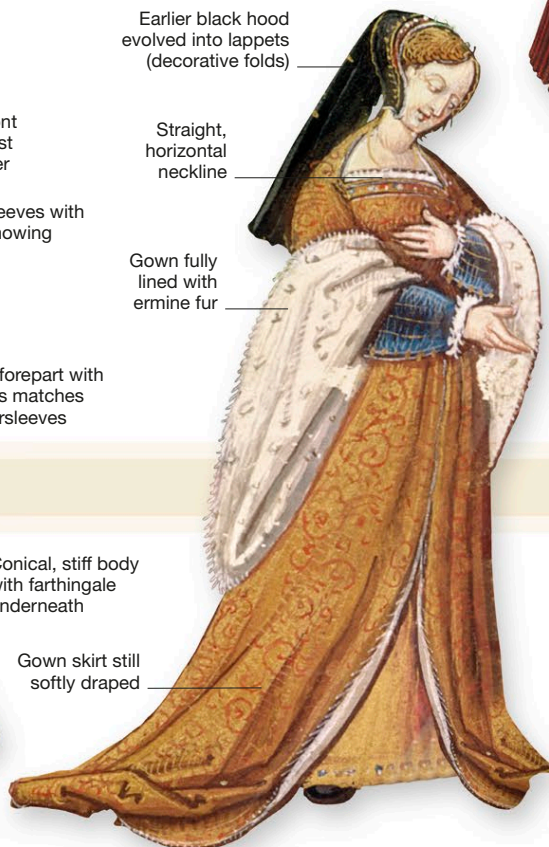


Earlier black hood evolved into lappets (decorative folds)

Straight, horizontal neckline

Gown fully lined with ermine fur

Gown skirt still softly draped



Fur-lined silk gown The huge sleeves of the Duchesse d'Etampes' 1540 French gown are turned back to reveal an expensive ermine fur lining. While her gown trails on the floor, the kirtle skirt is ankle length.

DEFINED SHAPE



Wired headdress support



Gable headdress

Fashion became architectural as the century progressed. Strong, new shapes distinct from bodylines were built over supports that kept the garments taut and straight. The English gable headdress used wire underneath to turn the 15th-century hood into a sharp peak. Spanish women began to wear horizontal willow hoops called *verdugado* (farthingale) under their skirts to make them stand out. Stiffened bodices flattened the bosom, creating an inflexible torso like an inverted triangle.